VIDEO · AI AGENTS · REQUIREMENTS

Should this be an AI agent?

"We need an AI agent for invoice approvals." Then you look at the process: three rules and a spreadsheet. That's not an agent. That's an IF statement wearing a blazer. Here's a 5-question test for BAs.

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WHY IT MATTERS

An expensive mix-up. And it has a name.

CANCELED

40%+

of agentic AI projects, by the end of 2027, in Gartner's forecast.

AGENT WASHING

Relabeled

Chatbots, RPA and old automation rebranded as "agents".

THE REAL THING

~130

of the thousands of agentic AI vendors, by Gartner's estimate.

Source: Gartner press release, 25 June 2025. Gartner also says many use cases pitched as agentic don't need an agent at all.

THREE LEVELS OF AUTOMATION

Vending machine, translator, new hire with a company card.

LEVEL 1 · RULES

Same input, same output. A workflow, a formula, a bot that clicks the same buttons.

LEVEL 2 · AI JUDGMENT

AI reads messy input and makes a judgment: label this email, pull the total off this PDF.

LEVEL 3 · AGENT

AI that takes actions across systems, several steps, on its own.

QUESTIONS 1 TO 3

Rules first. Then the mess.

1 **Can you write the decision as rules on one page?**

If yes, stop and build the rules. Cheaper, easier to test, and they never hallucinate. If nobody can, the policy isn't decided yet.

2 **Is the input messy?**

Free-text emails, scanned PDFs, voicemails: that's where AI earns its keep. A clean form? Sometimes the right AI is a dropdown.

3 **Does it need to act, or just recommend?**

Reading and suggesting is level 2. Clicking "approve" in three systems is level 3. Every action is one more thing that can go wrong at 2 AM.

QUESTIONS 4 AND 5

The undo test kills half the agent ideas.

4 · THE UNDO TEST

If it gets it wrong, can you undo it? A reviewed draft: easy. A refund, a deleted record, an email to ten thousand customers: no undo. No undo means a person approves the action. Every time.

5 · CAN YOU MEASURE "BETTER"?

Time per case, error rate, cost per case. Measure them today, before anything gets built. No baseline, no business case.

WORKED EXAMPLE · NORTHSTAR SYSTEMS (FICTIONAL)

Same five questions. Three different answers.

PROCESS	WHAT THE QUESTIONS SAY	LEVEL
Invoice matching	The rules fit on one page	Level 1
Refund emails	Messy input, but it only needs to recommend; a person approves	Level 2
Chasing vendors for missing invoices	Messy replies, sends emails, updates a tracker; a person approves the first message to each vendor	Level 3

"Should we use AI?" is the wrong question. "Which level does this process need?" is the right one.

BONUS TRICK · IN THE MEETING

Make the AI argue against the agent.

Paste the process into a model and ask it to argue against using an agent. If its best argument holds up, you just saved a budget line. Then don't say a flat "no". Say: "Let's start one level down and earn the next one."

FREE SCORING SHEET

The five questions, the three levels and the Northstar example on one page.

`github.com/prachitparikh/ba-toolkit`

WATCH THE FULL WALKTHROUGH

youtube.com/watch?v=AZLoC-rGk6Y

Three levels, five questions and the undo test, with a six-question quiz at the end.

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